

MODULE 20 / 40

Cedar Waxwing

Bombycilla cedrorum

QUICK STATS

Length	5.5 – 6.7 in (14 – 17 cm)
Wingspan	8.7 – 11.8 in (22 – 30 cm)
Weight	1.1 – 1.4 oz (32 – 40 g)
Lifespan	Up to 13 years (avg. 5 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Cedar Waxwing is perhaps the most elegantly plumaged bird in North America — a sleek, silky bird of extraordinary refinement, with smooth blended plumage in tones of warm brown, gray, and pale yellow, set off by a bold black mask, a brilliant yellow tail-tip band, and the mysterious red waxy droplets on its wing tips that give the species its name. These red tips are actually extensions of the feather shafts and increase in number with age — older birds have more, making them more attractive to potential mates. Cedar Waxwings are nomadic flock birds, appearing unpredictably wherever berries are abundant and stripping entire trees in a matter of hours.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Cedar Waxwing breeds across southern Canada and the northern United States, from British Columbia to Newfoundland and south through the Appalachians and northern Great Plains. In winter it roams widely across the entire contiguous United States and into Central America, following berry crops. It inhabits open woodlands, forest edges, orchards, suburban parks, and gardens — wherever fruiting trees and shrubs are present. It shows a particularly strong association with fruiting cedars, serviceberries, crabapples, and mountain ash.

DIET & FEEDING

- Wild berries — cedar, serviceberry, crabapple, hawthorn, holly
- Mountain ash berries — a winter favorite
- Dogwood, viburnum, and elderberry fruits
- Insects caught in aerial sallies during summer — especially near water
- Cherry and apple fruits — sometimes causing intoxication from fermentation
- Flower petals occasionally consumed in spring

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Cedar Waxwings are among the most social songbirds in North America, living in tight flocks year-round and rarely seen alone. Flocks move nomadically across the landscape, locating fruiting trees by sight and sound and descending en masse to strip them. They show a remarkable behavior of passing berries or flower petals beak-to-beak along a perched row of birds — an apparent bonding or courtship ritual. Unlike most songbirds, waxwings do not defend feeding territories and tolerate conspecifics freely at food sources. They are highly efficient berry consumers, capable of eating their body weight in fruit daily, and are important seed dispersers for many native plants.

NESTING & BREEDING

Cedar Waxwings are late nesters, typically not beginning until June or July to coincide with the peak availability of summer berries. They often nest in loose colonies. The female builds a bulky cup nest of grasses, twigs, and plant fibers in a tree fork, lined with fine grasses and hair. Clutches of 3–5 pale gray eggs with dark spots are incubated by the female for 11–13 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledged at 14–18 days. One to two broods per season.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Cedar Waxwing's vocalizations are among the most distinctive in North American birding — a high, thin, sibilant trill or whistle, often written as "seeeee" or "srrrrr," that is easily missed by those with high-frequency hearing loss. Flocks produce a constant soft chorus of these calls as they feed — often the first indication that waxwings are present overhead. They have no true song in the traditional sense.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Increasing
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The Cedar Waxwing population is estimated at 52 million individuals and has increased significantly since the 1960s, benefiting from the maturation of forest edges and the proliferation of ornamental fruiting trees in suburban landscapes. It is one of the few fruit-specialist songbirds to have thrived in human-modified environments. Window collisions are a significant mortality source for this species.

FEEDER TIPS

- Plant native serviceberry, crabapple, hawthorn, and holly — they don't use traditional feeders
- Mountain ash is one of the most reliable trees for attracting winter flocks
- Leave fruiting shrubs unpruned through winter — waxwings will find them
- A shallow birdbath near fruiting trees greatly increases attractiveness
- Listen for the high, thin "see" call overhead — often the first sign of a flock

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Head & crest	<i>Silky warm brown — tawny</i>
Black mask	<i>Bold black eye mask — both sexes</i>
Back & breast	<i>Smooth gray-brown, blending</i>
Belly	<i>Pale yellow fading to white</i>
Tail tip	<i>Bright yellow band</i>
Wing tips	<i>Red waxy droplets (adults)</i>

COLOR ME!

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